



The Modscene

H4xx0rs are not the only 1337 kids that dig into the source code, pull stuff apart, and put them back together in a better way...

Aditya Madanapalle

aditya.madanapalle@thinkdigit.com

Cog in the machine

Game modification is the creation of new gameplay environments or scenarios using a released game as the base. The Modscene came about as a result of a convergence of two trends of technology usage. Firstly, in a world where products were rolled out of an automated production line, users had a need to distinguish their own products from the rest. This involved either changing the surface of the product, say in painting a car in a particular way or adding vinyls. There were those who however, changed the inner workings, tuning the mechanics of a car for a particular purpose, and were interesting in making changes that were not just cosmetic. Washing machines, toasters, computer hardware, and software were all taken apart and put together better suited for a particular purpose. This trend is what is referred to as the "hacker ethic", finding out how something works by pulling it apart, and making it work better. This is analogous to putting a cog in the machine that makes it work better rather than

disturbing the way it functions. Secondly, the internet has helped considerably change the way in which media is produced and consumed. Technology has grown to a point where enthusiasts and amateurs can create and publish content on the lines of studio-backed media. This can range from fan flicks on the lines of big budget movies, to fan fiction using the same universe as popular books. Computer games were a very fertile ground for these two trends to come together. Not only could you get into computer games and change the way they work, but you could also put together modifications and share the content you created with other people.

Some of the really early games to encourage participation from the consumer in terms of creating the gameplay environment were games released with map editors. These were fairly simple editors, which simply involved a space where users could paint on objects, and save their creation as maps. These maps could be loaded, and the game could be played in the custom environment. It was in the early 90s, with games such as *Wolfenstein 3D*, *Doom* and *Quake* that the Modscene really took off. It was around the same time

that the internet also started spreading its tendrils across the planet, so communities could grow around the activity of modifying games. Game modification now is a much more complicated affair than simply editing maps or changing the way a particular game looks. Some of the people from the Modscene have been hired by the official developers of the game, for later iterations of the product, or for developing new games because of their experience in certain areas.

A typical modern computer game is broadly made up of two basic parts; the game engine and the libraries. The game engine consists of a set of rules, that govern how 3D objects are drawn, how they are painted, how characters within the game move, and a system for managing the physics of the game. Often, there are many game sub-engines, say a separate engine for managing the physics of projectiles like rockets and bullets, and an engine for managing the particles, as in smoke, fog, water and sparks. The library is a set of files that contains all the game information. This includes the maps, the models of the characters, the textures used to paint the surfaces, the weapons, the storyline etc.

The Doom days

Doom, when it was first released, the libraries of the game were saved in what are known as .WAD files. WAD is an acronym for "Where's all the Data?", and packaged the sprites, sounds and levels or maps together. 'Sprites' are animated or static pictures of all the elements in the game, including the characters, the

